

Location Specific Reflections : Upcountry

We visited Tea Leaf Trust (two sites), Grow, Welead & Ohiya

Tea Leaf Trust – Nuwara Eliya / Maskeliya

- “Tree of Life” wellbeing sessions
- Mobile Healthcare Circuit (dental, optometry, nutrition)
- Apprenticeship Challenge (community-development project)

GROW Centre – Nuwara Eliya

AI and Cybersecurity workshop for students

WeLead Hub – Hatton

- Parallel AI and Cybersecurity workshop

Ohiya Village

- Infrastructure site visit

Observations

Tea Leaf Trust

- NE workshops - Canva & IT created learning opportunities for students and teachers that they rarely get access to.

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- Presentation skills sometimes undermined how good their thinking and products were, it would be worth focussing on developing these skills to benefit the fayre and future employments. Public Speaking & Confidence.
- Innate artistic skills in the student - we should nurture this further and teach digital art / designing
- MS Office / Word should be introduced earlier & bring it up to a standard
- Healthcare observations
 - Lack of access to dental care + financial constraints
 - Lack of education on eye care - this is too broad
 - 3rd day eye camp - follow up with sorting out the distribution of glasses
 - Small - scale education would help solve a lot of the problems - came from misunderstandings / confusion.
 - Reflections on medical healthcare:
 - Research is needed to understand true circumstances of the people we visit in terms of access to food, access to healthcare before we give recommendations
 - Preventative education on certain topics is quite important, however the advice isn't effective as they don't have access to nutrition / good hygiene, etc., there are financial constraints, etc.
 - Malnutrition + acid reflux due to not eating
 - No cervical screens, pregnancy screens, etc.
- Children curious on various careers and pathways but lack of awareness - possible idea: create a doc/workshop outlining - use that Batticloa Secondary school for help + the speakers that we had come in and talk (Jarosan specifically)
- Start with one career pathway at a time e.g. BBK accountancy
- It would be cool to encourage students to keep a log of all their work that they're proud of for future use.

Activities with an ulterior motive to build technology / personal skills.

Communication about the upcountry issues on our social media - not much knowledge

Create a follow up call and tell them about our observations

To follow up on post trip:

Maskeliya:

- Healthcare camp:
 - Eye camp: arrange for an Optom to come in, check prescriptions + distribute glasses

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- Medical camp: sort through the healthcare data + highlight the most pressing cases + follow up in whatever way possible (e.g. speak to a SL doctor, potentially fund treatments etc.)

Batticaloa

1. SI - Optimising their schedules, give advice
2. Conference
 - a. Describing low level issues (unaware of implemented solutions?)
3. SJB
 - a. Scheme to send students abroad and then they come back and teach (positive)

Batticaloa: Vanni hope

- School
 - Nutrition
 - Career prospects
- Boys home
 - Need small infrastructure developments such as ceiling repair, playground repair, etc.
 - Lack of funding to pursue higher education
 - Need an english, IT and xx teacher
 - Children have gone through a lot of traumatic experiences - no prior psychological support
 - Very willing to learn + study but lack of funding
- Woman's society
 - Microfinance project established already
 - The politician that runs initiatives isn't actually following through with any proposed projects
 - Major issues (houses not made of concrete, elephants in their land, etc.) - needs larger scale input
- Kathiraveli hospital/ kattamurippu village (health camp)
 - Initiative that uses the females of the town and help make their own business
 - Know that referrals are being taken care off
 - More optom and dental help (professionals)
- Ampara district

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- Children drop out of education due to financial constraints - this means they can't break out of their poverty cycle
- Telungana area
 - They do laboural jobs under lots of other farms to earn basic income - potential area for us to rent a land / farm for them to work there and help themselves
 - schools are far away/buses don't come regularly - boy died whilst going to school on a truck they want a local school - need to think about how we can help here
 - Lots of women that want to work - no job opportunities
- School (primary visited with WASH)
- Infra development - toilets
- Thirukovil Base Hospital
 - Spotlight on leaders who are getting things done, good at allocating money. Empowering local leaders (they're stories) - use the media to do this.
- Sakthi illam: careers guidance. Plan for VM, potentially dance/singing workshops/ sewing training - could do smth with this in terms of selling products.
- Lack of English teachers

Macro Observation:

Children choose familiar routes because (a) theyre not exposed to different pathways and (b) theyre mindset is that other pathways are too difficult.

Trinco

1. HOPE
 - a. Staff need adequate training - children maltreated at the moment
 - b. No timetable or set schedule for the children at the moment
 - c. No measure of progress/development for the children
 - d. No personalised care for the children

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- e. Parents potentially setting up their own support group -> need to follow up potentially to see progress of this
- f. Parents fixed on their struggles and community stigma (understandably). If support group set up, this could help with emotional struggle. Parents need guidance on how to support each of their children individually (difficult with lack of opportunities)
- g. **Macro-observations**
 - i. Staff need better training
 - ii. No standardised method of tracking each child's needs and progress (e.g. EHCPs/individual care plan) -> therefore no progress with these children
 - iii. Lack of training centres / opportunities for the children
 - iv. **However**, the above may be better at other organisations/locations, we need to do more research

2. Anbu illam

- a. Weak english skills
- b. Children come from traumatic background
- c. Requested a good touch bad touch talk

3. Saratha

- a. Culture of girls getting married early, getting into relationships and jeopardising studies. Not willing to prioritise studies over culture
- b. Traumatic pasts have destroyed some girls' motivation to think about their future - counselling needed?

These are macro observations^

- 1. Female role models exposed - Sri Lanka, close to their age would help get resonate with the kids

Vavuniya

ORHAN: very similar to HOPE

Mannar

Factories:

- Lack of middle management, lack of initiative to improve the business, and distribution channel
- Finance, engineering, and legislation are required to improve the distribution channel
- Better cost breakdown required

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- Can use karavada factory as initial pilot

Sivan Arul:

- Great management
- Gold standard for child happiness

Soil Regeneration project:

- We need to find out what happens after the project ends- do they put forward a business proposal for x and y successful crop
- Getting local people to grow using abandoned land?

Mullaitivu:

TEN:

- No major observations - need to continue with Kullu project

Kilinocchi

Pannankandy:

- Children quite focused on playing, not interested in studying

Serendip special needs:

- Well run - good place to learn from and teach other homes, e.g. ORHAN, HOPE
- They had requests for us
 - Help finding occupational therapists
 - Parents need training on guiding their children with small life skills (e.g. nappy vs potty training)
 - Guidance on art therapy

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- Need help improving their social media and website

Serendip fine arts centre:

- Tapped buzz child - helping students with high potential further could be good
- Lots of low quality instruments

SEN Vocational training centre

- They choose higher functioning children and teach them IT skills or embroidery
- Only choose and work with certain organisations + students (due to poor experiences with HOPE)

Jaffna

New life foundation

- Business ideas from the presentation were not feasible
- Difficult to get a sustainable revenue model to keep the home running
- The war veterans are limited in their ability to work - online jobs/work/courses/training may be good
- Marketing workshop series - to be implemented/continued
- Get one good case study + let the others follow
- They need to think about it holistically (not just taking a photo, but marketing their product in the right environment)

Reflection summary

Sector	Key observations	Micro projects	Sector-specific	Macro projects
Community Development	• People are fixed into mindsets about how to make money and what are viable career path (aversion to business, many lack awareness altogether on how they would do this) • Business owners are unable to market their products effectively and don't have the knowledge of networks to do this • Soft skills that make people employable are lacking in the community as they have not had the opportunity or exposure to do this (limited work experience as they constantly go tuition, little English skills) • Many places lack basic needs (e.g. water, internet) and a fundamental economy for that matter • There are various social issues undermining societal progress now, often to a much greater extent than they were in the past (e.g. drug usage, early marriage, disengagement with politics) • Acquiring other rights with government support remain a challenge (e.g. land rights, ostracization of certain communities) • Some local leaders have very successfully created initiatives for development, sometimes in partnership with external bodies	Expanding TLT dragons den idea, makes it more serious. Sports team league - cricket, batticoloa Motivational speeches about careers, career pathway frameworks Expanding financial literacy project, long term setting up the bulletin board on the aram website	Setup sponsorship scheme, students apply with recommendation, they fill out specific needs to access higher education. Focus on advertising. Business consulting for small businesses (established, but need help to make the next step) - marketing, finance, engineering, logistics	

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	(e.g. Vanni Hope). However, government does not appear well tuned to economic development initiatives - Processes have potential to be streamlined (e.g. QA in factory, automation for TEN) - Economic development in Jaffna lags behind other regions in Sri Lanka with little containment of diaspora funding		Revolving microloans , low interest loans w Vanni Hope Setting up aram as a wholeseller / e-commerce platform that sources products from businesses in sri lanka, sells to diaspora (extremely long term) Fishing project	
Education	- English skills are a huge barrier for students and an area where this is huge appetite for learning - Education system currently fails to make students employable (few go to university from secondary schools and a bulk of these students do art subjects with minimal use, school gives little practical skills or knowledge on matters such as CVs, career paths, financial literacy) - Motivation to study is becoming an ever-increasing challenge with distractions such as phones and social media - Smart boards have proven to be interactive and facilitate remote learning		Help create career pathway profiles for different roles, get role models to do seminars in them and do this on a large scale across all our orphanages etc.	
Healthcare	- Education around causes of diseases is lacking - People highly value the opportunity of seeing a doctor and getting check-ups, but very rarely get follow ups they need or implement the lifestyle changes they need to make (reluctance and not taking it seriously)	Preventative workshops - videos, leaflets that are more tailored to their way of living		Telemedicine - not feasible right now need you build up a trustworthy network

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	• Medical coverage is insufficient due to lack of resources and attitudes from local healthcare professionals • Government support and aid is lacking	Fund fortified foods etc whole meal foods, vitamins Build a network between us and healthcare professionals in SL across optom/dentistry and med- so we are able to follow through with macro projects.		Organise healthcare camps led by SL volunteers/medical/dental students - can train them virtually from here/fund resources Organising a triage session - where you potentially have a doctor from here signposting and providing treatment/advice
SEN	• There is a lot of potential in creating support networks between SEN homes and between diaspora professionals and parents • Curriculum and engagement structure for children at homes is poor – many teachers seem to just look after the kids instead of seeking to maximise their potential with a development path (numerous kids have much higher IQs than they are treated) • Staff are undertrained and do not handle SEN behaviours • Many of the SEN homes lack specialised staff to meet the children's needs (e.g. behavioural psychologists) • ≈ Infrastructure in many of the SEN homes are inadequate		- Parent mini-workshop on daily-living skill coaching. - Social media & website refresh to showcase work/needs. - OT recruitment drive (diaspora and local).	- Design and implement a SEN training programme that is adapted and effective for Sri Lanka

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Technology	• When given the opportunity with technologies (e.g. Canva, Robotics), the children were very adept at picking up the skills needed, highlighting the potential for them to upskill given the right resources • Lack of hardware in some locations is a big blocker to learning (laptops insufficient, cramped into a room with other labs / equipment) • Many people have fallen victim to scams and fraud, which is becoming more prevalent in Sri Lanka		Virtual teaching in upcountry - games/ competitions Funding tech donations	helping other macro projects
Wellbeing	• Management understanding of sensitive topics (e.g. mental health, sexual harassment, abuse) is really poor and they are ill equipped to address them • Many children don't have an outlet for their problems (e.g. physical activity, mental distressers) and this contributes to poor mental health and social issues (e.g. drug usage) • The		• Gym - having bi-weekly session - enable discipline and help them with training • Penpal - more info needed? But from the trial it seems to be very doable • wellbeing / psychoeducation section on the website?	

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			Mental health research	
General	- Many locations struggle to establish models that enable consistent funding - Most locations have not scaled and rely on a single head with little middle management - Charity work needs to get traction behind it by communicating our vision, but also not be self-promotional in the way that some organisations in SL are conducting their activities	Leaders Spotlight - Media initiative in order to show whats been done to the diaspora.		Creating a place on our website to get funding requests and projects, communicated well so we can donate.

Initiative scoring

Sector	-Initiative	Impact score (1 to 10)	Feasibility score (1 to 10)	People
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Comm Dev	Revolving Microloans- Low interest loans for small businesses. Scalable across SL	8?	5 Lack of hard evidence that it's impactful with VH Monitoring spend is difficult	
Comm Dev	Small Business Consulting	8	7	Anehan, Gajeenth
Comm Dev	Aram Export Distribution Channel	9	2	
Comm Dev	Sponsorship Scheme for Higher Ed	7	6	
Comm Dev	Cricket PL Sponsorship	6	7	
Education	Career Pathway Seminars	6	8	Ajancia, Pavi
Healthcare	Telemedicine	9	1	
Healthcare	SL Student Led Medical Camps	? (unsure if med students would be best fit/have correct skills, e.g. doctors might be better)	5	
SEN	SEN Teachers Training Programme	7	7 (need a solid list of SL networks)	Sethu + Evona
General	Funding Request Platform	8	6 (need someone to design platform)	Vinu
General	Help pages - e.g. wellbeing, financial literacy	7	7	Nilaani, Anehan, Gajeenth
General	Volunteers Opportunities Page	8	7	Us

Impact potential

- **Expressed need** - Was this frequently cited as a major need during our trip?
- **Scale** - what is the reach and can it be replicated easily?
- **Equity** - Does it encompass all members of the community (e.g. age, gender, rural communities, ethnicity)?
- **Sustainability** - will this lead to lasting change (e.g. skill transfer, system change)?
- **Knock on impact** – what happens downstream because of this initiative? (e.g. investment pours in because labour is skilled)

Feasibility

- **Measurability** – can we track outcomes and success easily?
- **Skills** – do we have the skills IN THIS ROOM to execute this?
- **Resources** – what financial investment is needed and is this realistic?
- **Diaspora network** – do we have the connections IN THIS ROOM to get the right input for this?
- **SL partnerships** – can we get people in SL to execute this?
- **Time** – how long will this take to do realistically?
- **Political / cultural fit** – will there be resistance to this from locals / gov?

Initiative prioritisation



Funding requests

- **Maskeliya (Upcountry) – Healthcare**
 - Eye camp: fund an optometrist visit, prescriptions, and **purchase/distribution of glasses**.
 - Medical camp: budget to **triage cases** and **fund prioritized treatments** (via SL doctors; labs/meds).
 - Coding / software workshops and competitions
- **Vanni Hope**
 - **Small infrastructure**: ceiling repair, playground repair, minor works.
 - **Nutrition support** (ongoing).
 - **Higher-education bursaries** for students lacking funds.
 - **Teachers**: fund/stipend for **English, IT and a third subject (xx)**.
- **Schools / WASH**
 - **Toilet block / WASH infrastructure** at the primary school visited.
- **Healthcare access (general)**
 - **Dental care subsidies/clinics** for communities facing financial barriers.

- **Digital & skills enablement (where needed)**
 - Licences/training for **MS Office/Word**; **digital art/design** teaching resources.
 - Laptops and infrastructure for Grow/WeLead

Micro observations (local/operational)

- **Upcountry – Education/Tech**
 - NE workshops (Canva & IT) **opened rare learning opportunities** for students/teachers.
 - **Presentation/public speaking/confidence** gaps sometimes hid strong thinking/work; worth focused training.
 - **Innate artistic talent**—nurture via **digital art/design** skills.
 - **MS Office/Word** should be **introduced earlier** and **brought up to standard**.
 - Encourage **student portfolios** (logs of proud work).
 - Design **activities with an ulterior motive** to build tech/personal skills.
- **Healthcare (on the ground)**
 - **Lack of education on eye care**—current framing is too broad; use **small, targeted education** to address misunderstandings.
 - **3rd-day eye camp**: need to **sort and distribute glasses** (follow-up).
 - **Malnutrition & acid reflux** observed due to **not eating**.
 - The team should **research real circumstances** (food access, prior healthcare access) **before recommending**.
- **Careers & exposure**
 - Children **curious about careers** but **lack awareness**; create a **doc/workshop** (use Batticaloa Secondary + prior speakers, esp. Jarosan).
 - **Start with one pathway at a time** (e.g., **BBK accountancy**).
- **Comms & follow-ups**
 - **Share upcountry issues** on social media (low awareness).
 - **Set a follow-up call** to feed back observations.
 - **Batticaloa (SI)**: **optimise schedules**; provide advice.

Macro issues (structural/systemic)

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- **Healthcare & poverty constraints**
 - **Financial barriers** limit access to **dental care**, **nutrition**, and **hygiene**, blunting the impact of preventative advice.
 - **Limited healthcare access** overall; **no cervical or pregnancy screening** programs present.
- **Education system pressures**
 - **Children dropping out** due to **financial constraints** (Ampara) → intergenerational poverty cycle.
 - **System-level lack of career guidance/exposure** pathways.
 - **Shortage of qualified teachers** (English/IT/other) in local areas.
- **Governance & environment**
 - **Politician not following through** on proposed projects (accountability gap).
 - **Substandard housing** (non-concrete) and **human–elephant conflict** require **larger-scale, multi-stakeholder** solutions.